Bhutan, or ‘Bootan’, as it was spelled in the past, is most probably a derivative from the Indian term ‘Bhutia’ or ‘Bhotay’ in Nepali, which refers to peoples of Tibetan stock. But the Indo-Aryan term *bhot* could, in turn, be derived from the Tibetan word *bod*, which is what Tibet is called in Tibetan and Bhutanese dialects. The Tibetans call themselves *Bod-pa*, or inhabitant of Tibet.[12]

To strengthen his hold over his Thunder Dragon kingdom, the shabdrung built more and larger dzongs, which became centres of religious as well as secular power—the dual system of governance that is mentioned in modern Bhutan’s national anthem and which is followed, at least in theory, even today. The colossal dzongs of Thimphu, Paro, and Punakha trace their origin to the time of the first shabdrung. According to the British historian and Tibetologist Michael Aris,

> [e]very *dzong* was divided between an ecclesiastical wing occupied by state monks of the Drukpa school and a civil wing where the business of government was transacted and where the grain tax and other levies raised from the public could be deposited in storerooms[13]… the effectiveness of his rule was demonstrated before his death by tribute missions from all over the country and by embassies from neighbouring Indian states, Nepal and several Tibetan principalities.[14]

The head of the civil, but still theocratic, government was a *druk desi* who was either a monk or a layman.

The succession of the shabdrung was supposed to be by reincarnation in the manner of Tibet’s Dalai Lama. But when the first shabdrung died in 1651, his importance for the country was so great that his death was concealed for several years under the pretext that he was in a meditation retreat. And when his death became known, the search for a child into whose body he had been reborn began, with rival factions supporting at least five alternative reincarnations. The conflict was eventually settled when, in the 1730s, Bhutan was invaded by a military force from Tibet. According to Aris, this was ‘the only successful invasion of Bhutan by Tibet…[but] the campaign was in fact brought to an end more by an appeal for peace issued by the leading Tibetan lamas of the day than by outright conquest.’[15]

The country was divided into two states and both sides appealed to the authorities in Lhasa for mediation. But they also had to submit their case to the Chinese emperor, who claimed sovereignty over Tibet. Emissaries from